FROM THE MANUSCRIPTS
RECOVERED AT ARDENT KEEP

THE BLACKTOWER PAPERS

Being the surviving private writings of

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12 Nerament, 1444

Larrien has told me, for the better part of a year now, that I ought to put more of my thoughts to paper. She claims it might stop me from carrying them all to bed with me. I told her that if ink could quiet a man's mind, scribes would surely be the happiest men alive.

She did not find this especially clever.

Still, here I am, and perhaps there could have been no more fitting day to begin.

A messenger arrived this morning with news from Castonath. Korgus Dookanson is dead, and Corin with him.

I had often prayed to Castellos that I might live to hear the first, and dreaded that I might live to hear the second.

For twenty years we have lived behind Oldhaven's walls, counting those who escaped the Greentide and arguing over what remained of a realm most of us had not seen in years. Survival was once necessity, but somewhere along the way it became habit, and there are still men among the League who would mistake that habit for prudence.

Perhaps I am unfair to them. Fear kept many of us alive.

It also cost us dearly.

There are bargains a desperate man may justify while the enemy stands at his gate. There are fewer excuses once that enemy lies dead, and I suspect that thought troubles some of my fellow counts considerably less than it troubles me.

I have a letter from Lothane sitting unanswered on my desk. He would probably tell me that today, of all days, I ought to allow myself some measure of hope. I expect he is right, though I shall not give him the satisfaction of admitting it until I have replied.

Kalista would agree with him.

She was only six when we fled Castellyr, and I sometimes wonder how much of our old home Kalista truly remembers. To her, the places Larrien and I speak of must be little more than stories. She has grown up among Oldhaven's walls and the camps beyond them, and I suspect she occasionally finds my recollections rather tiresome.

She is hardly a child anymore, though I seem to require reminding of that more often than I should. Her interest in military matters has grown considerably, and I must admit she has developed a rather fine eye for terrain and the movement of troops. Not long ago she took issue with one of my proposed patrol routes, and I spent a good while explaining why I had chosen it before discovering that she had noticed a crossing I had overlooked. I was rather pleased with her, though I suspect I could have done a better job of showing it.

Larrien tells me I ought to encourage her more and correct her less. I suppose there is some wisdom in that, though I have no intention of letting the girl think she has nothing left to learn.

As for the League, I doubt the coming weeks will afford much peace. The soldiers are already asking when we march, while the displaced families want to know when they may finally return home. Even some of the older counts have discovered a remarkable enthusiasm for reclaiming their estates now that Dookanson is safely dead. I can hardly blame them for wanting to act, but the death of one orc, however mighty, has hardly restored Castellyr to us.

There will be plenty of time for councils, arguments and preparations in the days ahead. For this evening, at least, I would rather give some thought to Corin and what her sacrifice has meant for the rest of us.

There is still a bottle of Castonath vintage I managed to save when we fled. I had intended to keep it until we returned home, though tonight seems occasion enough. I think I shall find Larrien and Kalista and open it with them.

1 Castanmark, 1470